

Session 11: Formatting the Research Plan and Study Outline

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By the end of this session, participants should be able to

- ▶ Understand the standard structure of an institutional research plan
- ▶ Learn how to turn a concept note into a full research plan
- ▶ Understand the purpose of each section
- ▶ Develop a clear and logical document roadmap
- ▶ Learn how to present interdisciplinary and heterodox research clearly

Introduction

Part 1: The Institutional Research Plan

Part 2: The Policy Brief

Part 3: One More Lens – The Academic Paper

Part 4: Recap

1 The Institutional Research Plan

From concept note to a full document: structure, workplan, budget, team

2 Formatting Principles

Making any research document easy to navigate and consistent

3 The Policy Brief

Distilling the research plan into a short, decision-ready document

4 Practice & Recap

Applying the framework to your own concept note

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What makes a good research plan?

- ▶ From a research idea > research question > research design > evidence > contribution
- ▶ A research plan is a **MAP**
- ▶ Good research begins with a meaningful problem
 - What is the problem?
 - Why does it matter?
 - What do we not know?
 - How will we investigate it?

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Concept note

- ▶ Research idea
- ▶ Problem statement
- ▶ Preliminary questions
- ▶ Initial literature
- ▶ Proposed approach

Research plan

- ▶ Executive summary
- ▶ Background & problem
- ▶ Research questions
- ▶ Literature & theoretical framework
- ▶ Methodology
- ▶ Workplan
- ▶ Outputs
- ▶ Budget
- ▶ References
- ▶ Appendices

A concept note explains what you *want to study*. A research plan explains what you *will study, why, how, when, and with what resources*.

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The crosswalk: Concept Note → research plan

Each concept note element expands into one or more plan sections:

Concept note		Research plan section(s)
Research idea	→	Executive Summary
Problem statement	→	Background & Rationale; Research Problem
Preliminary questions	→	Research Objectives; Research Questions
Initial literature	→	Literature Review; Conceptual/Theoretical Framework
Proposed approach	→	Methodology; Research Activities & Timeline
(not yet specified)	→	Outputs; Team & Responsibilities; Budget; Appendices

Notice the plan asks for things the concept note never had to specify – that expansion is the work of this session.

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A research plan should allow a reader to answer five questions quickly:

▶ **WHY?**

What is the problem?

▶ **WHAT?**

What will the study investigate?

▶ **HOW?**

How will it be investigated?

▶ **WHEN?**

When will activities take place?

▶ **SO WHAT?**

What will the study contribute?

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The standard structure for a comprehensive institutional research plan:

- ▶ Executive Summary
- ▶ Background and Rationale
- ▶ Research Problem
- ▶ Research Objectives
- ▶ Research Questions
- ▶ Literature Review
- ▶ Conceptual/Theoretical Framework
- ▶ Methodology
- ▶ Expected Results & Contribution
- ▶ Policy Relevance / Implications
- ▶ Research Activities & Timeline
- ▶ Research Outputs
- ▶ Team & Responsibilities
- ▶ Budget
- ▶ References
- ▶ Appendices

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The one section every reader reads. In half a page, it should answer:

- ▶ What is the research problem, and why does it matter?
- ▶ What is the research question?
- ▶ What approach/methodology will be used?
- ▶ What contribution or expected results will the study produce?

Target: 200–300 words

Write it last, but place it first – it should stand alone if nothing else is read.

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Appendices hold material that supports the plan without interrupting its flow:

Belongs in appendices:

- ✓ Full data tables / codebook
- ✓ Survey instrument or interview guide
- ✓ Robustness checks, extra model specifications
- ✓ Ethics/IRB approval documentation
- ✓ Sampling frame and technical notes

Stays in main text:

- x Headline results and key tables
- x Anything needed to follow the argument
- x Summary figures readers must see

Rule of thumb: if removing it would break the argument, it's not an appendix.

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Activity	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6
Literature review	✓	✓				
Research design	✓	✓				
Data collection		✓	✓			
Data analysis			✓	✓		
Draft report				✓	✓	
Review & revision					✓	✓
Dissemination						✓

Tip: Ensure the timeline is consistent with the methodology and outputs.

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Clearly specify what will be produced.

Primary outputs

- ▶ Research report
- ▶ Working paper
- ▶ Policy brief
- ▶ Academic article

Data outputs

- ▶ Clean dataset
- ▶ Codebook
- ▶ Methodological documentation

Knowledge dissemination

- ▶ Workshop
- ▶ Seminar
- ▶ Conference presentation
- ▶ Public communication

Tip: Align these outputs with the activities in your workplan and the deliverables in your budget.

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Show who does what.

Role	Responsibility
Principal Investigator	Overall research leadership
Researcher	Literature review & analysis
Field team	Data collection
Data analyst	Data processing & analysis
Research assistant	Literature/data support
Reviewer	Quality assurance

Tip: A clear division of roles helps demonstrate feasibility and strengthens the proposal's credibility.

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Connect the budget to research activities.

Budget Category	Linked Research Activity / Justification
Personnel	Research leadership, literature review, data collection, analysis
Data collection	Fieldwork, surveys, interviews, focus groups
Travel	Field visits, partner meetings, conference attendance
Training	Capacity building for field team / enumerators
Software	Data analysis (e.g., Stata, NVivo), reference management
Research materials	Questionnaires, equipment, stationery, printing
Dissemination	Workshops, seminars, policy brief production
Publication	Journal submission fees, open access charges, printing
Administrative costs	Office support, logistics, communication

Key principle: Every major budget item should have a clear connection to a research activity.

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Use a consistent hierarchy:

- ▶ **1. Main heading**
- ▶ **1.1 Subheading**
- ▶ **1.1.1 Sub-subheading**

Also maintain:

- ▶ Consistent fonts
- ▶ Consistent heading sizes
- ▶ Page numbers
- ▶ Table numbers
- ▶ Figure numbers
- ▶ Captions
- ▶ Margins
- ▶ Line spacing
- ▶ Citation style
- ▶ Header/footer

"Good formatting is not decoration. It improves the reader's ability to understand the research."

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Avoid these pitfalls to keep your document coherent and credible:

- ▶ Long paragraphs with no headings
- ▶ Inconsistent numbering
- ▶ Tables without titles
- ▶ Figures without sources
- ▶ References missing from the text
- ▶ References listed but never cited
- ▶ Research questions don't match objectives
- ▶ Methodology doesn't answer the RQs
- ▶ Timeline doesn't match activities
- ▶ Budget doesn't match the workplan
- ▶ Important technical info buried in main text

“Internal consistency is the hallmark of a well-crafted research plan.”

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Fill this in for your own project – one line per section is enough for now.

Executive Summary:	...	Expected Results & Contribution:	...
Background & Rationale:	...	Policy Relevance:	...
Research Problem:	...	Activities & Timeline:	...
Research Objectives:	...	Research Outputs:	...
Research Questions:	...	Team & Responsibilities:	...
Literature Review:	...	Budget:	...
Theoretical Framework:	...	References:	...
Methodology:	...	Appendices:	...

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Before submitting a research plan:

- ☐ Is the research problem clear?
- ☐ Is the rationale convincing?
- ☐ Are objectives specific?
- ☐ Are research questions answerable?
- ☐ Is the literature organised around debates?
- ☐ Is the theoretical perspective clear?
- ☐ Does the methodology fit the questions?
- ☐ Is the interdisciplinary contribution explained?
- ☐ Are outputs clearly defined?
- ☐ Is the timeline realistic?
- ☐ Does the budget match the activities?
- ☐ Are references consistent?
- ☐ Are appendices properly organised?
- ☐ Is the document easy to navigate?

"A thorough final check ensures credibility and increases the chances of approval."

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What is a policy brief?

A policy brief is a **short, evidence-based document** designed to help policymakers and other decision-makers understand:

- ▶ **What** is the problem?
- ▶ **Why** does it matter?
- ▶ **What** does the evidence tell us?
- ▶ **What** can be done?

A policy brief is not a shortened academic paper.

It prioritises clarity, evidence, relevance, and actionable recommendations.

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Understanding the difference:

Research Report	Policy Brief
Comprehensive	Selective
Academic audience	Policy/practitioner audience
Detailed literature review	Key evidence
Extensive methodology	Essential methodology only
Detailed results	Main findings
Academic contribution	Policy implications
Longer	Shorter
"What do we know?"	"What should decision-makers consider?"

A policy brief distills research into actionable insights for decision-makers.

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Start with the policy problem

Don't begin with:

"This study examines..."

Begin with:

What policy problem requires attention?

Example:

Broad topic

Youth employment



Policy problem

Young workers face increasing difficulty accessing stable, productive employment.



Policy question

What policies can improve the quality and sustainability of youth employment?

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A practical policy brief can follow:

- 1 Title
- 2 Executive Summary / Key Messages
- 3 Policy Problem
- 4 Why Does It Matter?
- 5 What Does the Evidence Show?
- 6 Interpretation / Analysis
- 7 Policy Options
- 8 Recommendations
- 9 Implementation Considerations
- 10 Conclusion
- 11 Sources / References
- 12 Methodological Note (if necessary)

A clear structure helps readers quickly find the information they need.

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Working title: ...

Policy problem: ...

Target audience:
Who needs to read this?

Key policy question: ...

Main message: ...

Key findings: 1. ...

2. ...

3. ...

Evidence:
What data/research supports each finding?

Interpretation:
Why is this happening?

Policy options:

1. ...

2. ...

3. ...

Recommended actions:

1. ...

2. ...

3. ...

Responsible stakeholders: ...

Expected policy impact: ...

Sources: ...

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A good outline ensures clarity and focus throughout the writing process.

Recommended length and proportion

For a short institutional policy brief, a useful starting structure might be:

3000 words (main text)

Section	Pages	Words (approx.)
Executive Summary + Key Messages	1	300
Policy Problem + Context	1–2	300–600
Evidence + Analysis	2–3	600–900
Policy Options + Recommendations	1–2	300–600
Conclusion + Sources	1/2–1	150–300
Total	5.5–9	1650–2700

The exact length should follow the institution's requirements.

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A policy brief should be **scannable**.

Do Use:

- ✓ Short paragraphs
- ✓ Headings
- ✓ Bullet points
- ✓ Highlight boxes
- ✓ 2–4 key charts
- ✓ Simple tables
- ✓ Call-out statistics
- ✓ Source notes

Avoid:

- ✗ Dense academic paragraphs
- ✗ Huge tables
- ✗ Excessive footnotes
- ✗ Too many charts
- ✗ Unexplained technical terms

Make every element serve the reader's understanding.

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The "30-second test"

Ask a colleague to look at your policy brief for **30 seconds**.

Can they identify:

? **The problem?**

Why it matters?

! **The main finding?**

What you recommend?

If not, the brief needs restructuring.

The 30-second test is more useful than reading it aloud yourself — you know the content too well to judge fairly.

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- ▶ There is no strict rule for a paper structure
- ▶ Rule of thumb – let three things decide it:
 - 1 Your research question
 - 2 Your audience
 - 3 Your publisher's requirement
- ▶ The research plan, the policy brief, and the academic paper are the **same underlying research**, shaped for three different readers

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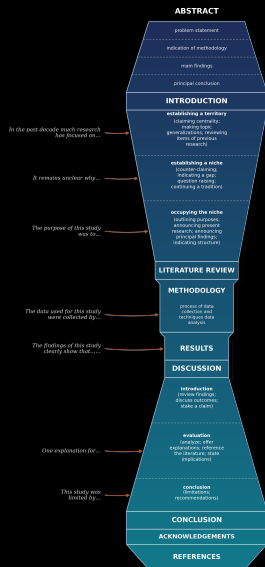
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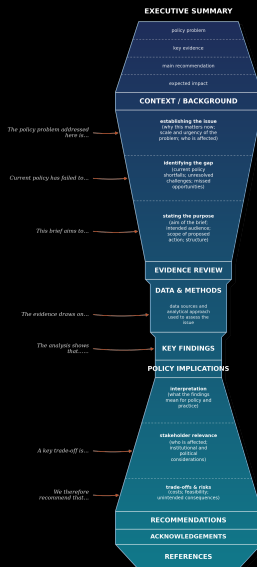
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Paper Outline: The Hourglass Model

The Hourglass Structure of a Research Article



The Hourglass Structure of a Policy Brief



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Exercise 1a: Fill your template

10 minutes, individually

- 1 Take your own concept note
- 2 Use the *Crosswalk* to see which plan section each element expands into
- 3 Fill in the *Research Plan Template* – one line per section, no need for full prose yet
- 4 Flag the one section you are least sure how to write

It's fine to leave a section blank – a visible gap is more useful than a vague one.

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Exercise 1b: Peer review with the checklist

10 minutes, in pairs

- 1 Swap your filled template with a partner
- 2 Go through the *Final Checklist* against **their** draft, item by item
- 3 For every unchecked box, write one sentence on what's missing
- 4 Return the draft and discuss the section they flagged in 1a

Be ready to share one checklist item that was hardest to satisfy – we'll troubleshoot it together.

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One research project, three documents:

- ▶ **Research plan** – answers WHY, WHAT, HOW, WHEN, SO WHAT for reviewers and funders
- ▶ **Policy brief** – distills the same evidence into a 30-second, decision-ready read
- ▶ **Academic paper** – shaped by your research question, audience, and publisher

Whatever the format:

- ▶ Consistent structure and formatting build credibility
- ▶ Every section should answer a question the reader actually has
- ▶ A plan is a starting point for thinking – not a prison for your ideas

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Thank you!

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